



“We took our first step with the launch of the Champions League of Cricket in 2019, achieving remarkable global television success of 140 million viewers”

ROGER FEINER
CEO, EUROPEAN CRICKET
LEAGUE AG

Premier League, Bangladesh Premier League, and Australia’s Big Bash League have gained traction internationally. Even China has a national cricket team.

The popularity of the shorter format has helped other cricketing leagues raise money. In July 2023, Major League Cricket (MLC), a professional T20 tournament, was launched in the US with six teams, including Los Angeles Knight Riders and MI New York. The investors include Microsoft CEO Satya Nadella, technology entrepreneur Anand Rajaraman and Adobe’s former CEO Shantanu Narayen.

“While the audience for the MLC will not be anywhere as large as for the IPL, the quality of the audience is extremely high, given that the Indian diaspora has the

highest income ranking among all ethnic communities in the USA, with the rest of the South Asian diaspora added in too,” says Balu Nayar, former MD of IMG and a key architect of the IPL. The prime audience of the MLC will be the south Asian demographic in the US that numbers around 5.4 million.

“It was very well received and has given us a lot of confidence,” says Pisike. The USA under-19 women’s team played a three-match series against South Africa. The men too have slowly made a mark. “There is a lot of talent in the US coming from the immigrant families, with the next generation taking to the game,” he points out.

However, Pisike maintains the game must be accepted by people

outside that populace to make it “commercially viable.” If the US is the world’s largest economy, the potential from cricket cannot be ignored. “There is no doubt that 80% of cricket’s global revenues come from India but the US is the second-largest market in terms of viewership,” he adds.

NEED FOR ORGANIC GROWTH

Despite the sport’s globalisation, challenges remain. Discussions around creating sustainable revenue models remain limited, particularly outside traditional cricketing nations. While leagues like the IPL and The Hundred have demonstrated commercial viability, emerging markets such as the US and Europe are still in early stages of monetisation.

Historically, cricket’s revenue model has relied heavily on media rights, with broadcasting deals generating the majority of earnings. Matchday revenue from ticket sales plays a relatively minor role in the financial model.

Organisations are working to address issues such as broadcast reach and revenue models. “We took our first step with the launch of the Champions League of Cricket in 2019, achieving remarkable global television success of 140 million viewers,” Feiner points out. Now, it hosts over 1,600 matches and has Dream11 as the main partner.

Making cricket commercially viable would require consistent efforts. However, costs remain a barrier to cricket’s global growth. Unlike soccer, cricket requires significant investment in gear and infrastructure. “Building proper pitches and investing in equipment poses challenges,” says Francis. **BT**

@krishnagopalan